

# The Iron Crucible

A Combat-Heavy Military Campaign for *Fate's Edge*

*Tiers II–IV — 6–10 sessions — Siege warfare, mercenary politics, war magic*

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*“The Granite Gate has never fallen. The River of Blades runs red. The Citadel of Ash waits. You are the Iron Phoenix – a company of sell-swords, exiles, and debtors. Your contract is simple: break what cannot be broken. Your payment is a name cleared, a fortune earned, or a grave forgotten. The war machine has teeth. Let’s see if yours are sharper.”*

## Campaign Overview

*The Iron Crucible* is a three-part military campaign for *Fate's Edge* that puts players in command of a mercenary company. Each part escalates the scale of conflict – from fortress siege to river war to city-wide annihilation – while keeping the core mechanics of *Fate's Edge* (Position, Effect, timers, Story Beats) front and centre.

### The Iron Phoenix

The players are the officers of the **Iron Phoenix**, a mid-sized mercenary company hired by a desperate coalition. The company has a reputation track, resource timers, and a roster of lieutenants. Between missions, players manage logistics, negotiate contracts, and decide which tactics to employ.

### The Three Crucibles

- **Part I: The Granite Gate** (Tier II) – Breach an impregnable fortress using siegecraft, subterfuge, or storm.
- **Part II: The River of Blades** (Tier III) – Control a strategic waterway, fight naval actions, and secure a bridgehead.
- **Part III: The Citadel of Ash** (Tier IV) – Conquer a cursed city, capture or destroy magical WMDs, and face the enemy’s last stand.

## Mercenary Company Rules

The company has four timers that represent its ability to fight. Players must manage these between sessions.

- **Manpower [8]** – Number of able troops. Drops from casualties. Can be replenished with coin or recruitment scenes.
- **Supplies [6]** – Food, ammunition, and repair materials. Resupply costs silver or favours.
- **Morale [8]** – Discipline and spirit. Low morale causes Desperate starts in battles.
- **Reputation [6]** – Fame and trust among employers. High reputation opens better contracts and allies.

At the end of each mission (or when the party takes downtime), the GM may ask for a **Company Roll**: the player with the highest Command rolls Presence + Command (DV based on current situation). On a success, one timer of their choice advances by 1; on a failure, a timer of the GM’s choice ticks backward.

## Company Assets

The party can acquire assets (siege weapons, scouts, war mages, etc.) by spending rewards or completing side objectives. Each asset grants a one-time tactical bonus (e.g., +1 Position on a certain roll) or unlocks a special action.

## Combat Position in Mass Battles

Instead of individual positioning, squads use the same Position ladder:

- **Dominant** – Flanking, high ground, prepared ambush.
- **Controlled** – Standard engagement, cover available.
- **Desperate** – Pinned, surrounded, outnumbered.

The GM sets the Position based on the party's tactical choices before each engagement.

## Part I: The Granite Gate (Tier II)

### The Situation

The Granite Gate is a fortress carved into a mountain pass, held by General Vorlag's veteran garrison. The Iron Phoenix has been hired to open the gate for a coalition army. Three approaches are possible, each represented by a timer. The party can attempt one or more in parallel, but splitting forces risks casualties.

- **Main Gate Assault** [8] – Direct battering ram and ladder assault. High risk, high reward.
- **Cliffside Scalpers** [6] – Stealth climb up the sheer north face. Requires Athletics and Stealth tests.
- **Underminers** [6] – Tunnel through the mountain's weak rock. Requires Craft and endurance.

Once any timer fills, the party gains a foothold. To complete the siege, they must also fill the **Gatehouse Control** [10] timer. Each successful assault action ticks this timer; enemy counter-actions can tick it backward.

### Key Scenes

**The Killing Ground** Open courtyard overlooked by murder holes. **Position: Desperate** for crossing unless the party creates cover (e.g., using siege shields, war magic, or smoke). **DV 4** for a squad to cross without casualties. On a 1, an oil pot ignites – Harm 1 to a squad.

**Arrow Storm Passage** A long corridor with arrow slits. **Position: Controlled** if advancing with tower shields; **Desperate** if rushing. **Clock** [6] to clear the archers. On a miss, the party loses 1 Manpower.

**General Vorlag's Last Stand** The old general retreats to the inner keep. He offers a deal: safe passage for his garrison in exchange for the gate's keys. The party must choose – honour the deal (gains Reputation, loses loot) or fight (tough battle, gains plunder but loses Morale).

## War Magic Options (Casters/Runekeepers)

- **Earthworks (Standard)** – Create a wall of packed earth (DV 4, Ritual). Grants Controlled Position for one scene.
- **Siege Ward (Standard)** – Protect a squad from ranged attacks (gain +1 armor). Lasts one engagement.
- **Logistics Blessing (Low)** – Create food and water for a day. Restores 1 Supply.

## Story Beat Table (Granite Gate)

- **1 SB** – A murder hole opens above a PC; test Body + Athletics or take Harm 1.
- **2 SB** – Vorlag's sappers collapse a tunnel. Choose: lose 2 Manpower or abort the underminer approach.
- **3 SB** – A traitor among the coalition reveals the party's plan. One approach timer ticks backward by 2.
- **4+ SB** – The gate's ancient wards activate. All magic becomes Desperate for one scene.

## Part II: The River of Blades (Tier III)

### The Situation

The coalition must cross the River of Blades, a fast-flowing waterway patrolled by Admiral Kessel's river fleet. The party must secure a bridgehead and then protect supply convoys. Three timers track progress:

- **Enemy Fleet Strength [8]** – Destroy or capture enemy vessels.
- **Bridgehead Establishment [6]** – Secure a landing zone on the far bank.
- **Supply Line Security [6]** – Keep resupply barges safe from raiders.

The final battle is a naval engagement represented by the **Decisive River Battle [10]** timer. Each successful boarding action, ramming, or artillery strike ticks the timer; enemy counter-attacks can reverse progress.

### Naval Combat Actions

Instead of individual movement, the party chooses a tactic each round:

- **Ramming** – Risk damage for instant boarding advantage. Test Body + Pilot (DV 4). On success, enemy vessel is locked; on failure, your ship takes Harm 1.
- **Boarding Action** – Close combat between vessels. Use squad rules. Position depends on relative speed and size.
- **Fire Ship** – Deploy a drifting fire barge to create an area denial zone. Any ship in the zone takes Harm 1 per round.
- **Archery Exchange** – Ranged volley. Test Wits + Ranged (DV 3). On success, tick Enemy Fleet Strength by 1 and reduce enemy's return fire.

## Vessel Types (choose or earn)

| Vessel          | Advantages                       | Weaknesses               |
|-----------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------|
| War Galley      | +2 dice to boarding, high armour | Slow, vulnerable to fire |
| River Sloop     | +1 dice to manoeuvres, fast      | Low armour, small crew   |
| Fire Barge      | Area denial, cheap               | One-use, drifts randomly |
| Troop Transport | Carries 3 squads                 | Very slow, easy target   |

## Admiral Kessel's Ambush

The enemy admiral is a master of deception. At any point, the GM may spend 3 SB to trigger a **River Ambush**: the party's vessel is suddenly flanked by hidden enemy boats. Position becomes Desperate for one exchange unless the party had previously scouted (Wits + Survival, DV 5).

## Story Beat Table (River of Blades)

- **1 SB** – A sudden current shift pushes the party's boat off course. Delay 1 segment.
- **2 SB** – A fire ship drifts into the supply convoy. Lose 1 Supply or take Harm 1 to a squad.
- **3 SB** – Admiral Kessel personally leads a boarding party. He is a Tier III adversary with elite marines.
- **4+ SB** – The river's spirit awakens (angry due to the battle). It demands a sacrifice – a memory, a weapon, or a life – before letting any vessel pass.

## Part III: The Citadel of Ash (Tier IV)

### The Situation

The enemy has retreated to a cursed city, once a capital of a fallen empire. Three magical WMDs are hidden in the city: the **Sun-Thrower** (laser siege weapon), the **Quake Engines** (collapse buildings), and the **Plague Cauldrons** (biological warfare). The party must capture or destroy them while controlling seven districts.

### District Control Clock [12]

Each district can be held by either side. The party gains 1 tick per district controlled at the end of each session. When the timer fills, the coalition declares victory. However, the enemy can launch counter-attacks (GM spends SB) to retake districts.

## Districts (with control values)

| District         | Control Value         | Special Rule                                 |
|------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Wizard's Quarter | 3                     | Magical hazards, teleportation circles       |
| Market Square    | 2                     | Ambush opportunities, civilian crowds        |
| Noble Heights    | 2                     | Defensible positions, political hostages     |
| Docks            | 1                     | Naval support access                         |
| Temple District  | 1                     | Healing sanctuary (restore 1 Harm per scene) |
| Slums            | 1                     | Guerrilla warfare, hidden passages           |
| Citadel          | 4 (victory condition) | Final objective, heavy fortifications        |

## Magical WMD Rules

Each weapon is a **Tier IV** obstacle that requires a specialised skill challenge to seize.

**Sun-Thrower** A massive lens that projects a beam of pure light. **Capture Clock [8]**. Each attempt requires a Wits + Craft (DV 5) to redirect the mirrors. Failure causes a burst that deals Harm 2 to the party.

**Quake Engines** Machines that cause building collapses. **Capture Clock [6]**. Requires Body + Athletics (DV 4) to stabilise the resonators. On a miss, the building the party is standing on collapses (Harm 1, all actions Desperate for one round).

**Plague Cauldrons** Vats of alchemical pestilence. **Capture Clock [6]**. Requires Spirit + Lore (DV 4) to neutralise the toxins. On a miss, the cauldron leaks – the party gains the *Plague* condition (–1 die to all physical actions until they receive treatment).

## The Bloody Baron's Last Stand

The enemy commander, the Bloody Baron, is a fanatic. He will not surrender. Instead, he offers a deal: he will destroy the city and all WMDs unless the party lets him escape with his elite guard. The party must choose: let him go (lose Reputation, avoid final battle) or fight him (epic confrontation, risk massive casualties).

## Story Beat Table (Citadel of Ash)

- **1 SB** – Rubble blocks a key route. Lose 1 segment of progress on a district control.
- **2 SB** – Civilian refugees clog a district. Using area weapons would kill innocents – gain +1 Morale if you avoid them, –1 Reputation if you don't.
- **3 SB** – A WMD malfunctions and begins a countdown. The party has 3 rounds to disarm or evacuate the district.
- **4+ SB** – The Hollow's attention turns to the city. A Oath-Keeper appears and demands that the party stop using the WMDs – or it will claim the souls of everyone in the district.

## Company Management Between Missions

After each part, the party has a downtime phase. They may:

- **Recruit** (**Command** + **Presence**, **DV 3**) – Restore 1d4 Manpower.
- **Resupply** (**Wits** + **Commerce**, **DV 4**) – Restore 1d4 Supplies, costing 1 Boon or a Diamond.
- **Train** (**Spirit** + **Command**, **DV 4**) – Advance one squad’s specialisation (see below) or improve Morale by 1.
- **Network** (**Presence** + **Sway**, **DV 3**) – Gain a new contact or a rumour about the next mission.

## Squad Specialisations

Once the company has Morale 6+ and has completed two missions, squads can be specialised. Choose one:

| Specialisation | Benefit                                                    |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shock Troops   | +1 Effect on charge attacks                                |
| Skirmishers    | Ignore difficult terrain penalties                         |
| Archers        | Ranged attacks at +1 die                                   |
| Engineers      | +1 die to craft and siege actions                          |
| Medics         | Reduce squad casualties by 1 level (e.g., Harm 2 → Harm 1) |

## XP Progression

XP is awarded at the end of each session as per standard *Fate’s Edge* guidelines, plus:

- Completing a part: +10 XP.
- Capturing a WMD: +5 XP each.
- Achieving a major moral victory (e.g., sparing civilians, refusing a dishonourable order): +3 XP.
- Losing a squad or company asset: –2 XP (narrative loss).

## NPC Adversaries (Quick Stats)

| NPC                 | Role                 | Tier | Special                                   |
|---------------------|----------------------|------|-------------------------------------------|
| General Vorlag      | Defensive genius     | III  | Fortifications gain +1 DV                 |
| Admiral Kessel      | Naval ambusher       | III  | Ambush at Sea: starts one Position higher |
| Archmage Theron     | War magic expert     | IV   | Enemy spells at +1 die                    |
| The Bloody Baron    | Fanatic leader       | IV   | Morale checks at +1 DV                    |
| Iron Legion Captain | Elite heavy infantry | III  | Armour 2, can use Shield Wall             |

# Running the Campaign

## Pacing

- Part I: 2–3 sessions.
- Part II: 2–3 sessions.
- Part III: 3–4 sessions.

Adjust by focusing on key scenes and using SB spends to create drama.

## Tone

This campaign is meant to be gritty, desperate, and morally grey. Emphasise the cost of war – dead allies, ruined cities, and the weight of command. Reward creative tactics and penalise reckless bloodshed.

## Integration with Core Fate’s Edge

All rules from the core SRD apply. Use Position/Effect for every roll. Clocks track progress and pressure. Story Beats are the GM’s tool to introduce unexpected complications. The company timers replace detailed resource tracking.